

Using CAC Bar Scanner

A step-by-step guide for operators and admins. Keep this open next to the kiosk.

 **Project home:** <https://github.com/NuclearChickens/CAC-Bar-Scanner> · Direct download: <https://github.com/NuclearChickens/CAC-Bar-Scanner/raw/main/BarScanner.exe>

At a glance

Tab	What it's for
Scanner	The main screen. Verdict on every CAC swipe.
Hours	When the bar is “open” — operating hours or rolling window.
Limits	Max drinks per person per session.
Roster	Which DoD categories and branches are allowed to drink.
Banned	Specific DoD IDs that are denied no matter what.
Reset	Wipe today's drink counts and change the admin password.
Logs	Read-only history of every admin action.
Backup	Export or import settings + logs.

All settings tabs are **locked by default**. Entering the admin password unlocks them for 5 minutes. See [Unlocking settings](#).

 **First launch:** the default admin password is `admin`. Change it the first time you unlock — see [Changing the admin password](#).

Install — step by step

The first time you set up a PC. You need admin rights on the machine.

- 1 **Download the app.** Open the project home page (URL at the top of this guide) and click the  **Download BarScanner.exe** button near the top. Your browser saves the file to your **Downloads** folder.
- 2 **Open it.** Open File Explorer → **Downloads** → double-click `BarScanner.exe`.
- 3 **Tell Windows to trust it.** If you see a blue *“Windows protected your PC”* box, click **More info** → **Run anyway**. (This appears because the app isn’t code-signed, not because anything is wrong. Windows remembers your choice.)
- 4 **Click “Install” in the first-run dialog.** When the app opens for the first time it asks if it should install for this PC.
- 5 **Approve the UAC prompt.** A blue *User Account Control* box from Windows pops up — click **Yes**.
- 6 **You’re done.** With that one click the app:
 - copied itself into `C:\Program Files\CAC Bar Scanner\`,
 - added itself to the Start menu for every user on the computer,
 - set up the shared data folder at `C:\ProgramData\CACBarScanner\`,
 - registered itself in **Settings** → **Apps** so it can be uninstalled cleanly.



Tip: Once installed, you can safely delete the copy in Downloads. The Start menu and taskbar use the Program Files copy.

“Not now” instead of Install

If you click **Not now**, the app still runs but only from wherever you double-clicked it, without a Start menu entry or shared data folder. The dialog won’t reappear for the same Windows account, but will appear the next time a *different* user logs in and tries the app. Once anyone clicks **Install**, the offer is dismissed for everyone.

Re-running install from inside the app

If the first-run dialog has already been dismissed (or you can’t find the Start menu entry afterwards), you can re-trigger the install at any time:

- 1 Open the **Backup** tab.

- 2 The **PC install** box at the top shows whether the app is installed for this PC and the exact path the shortcut should land at.
- 3 Click **Install for this PC...** (or **Reinstall...** if it's already installed) and approve the UAC prompt. Reinstall is safe — it just refreshes the shortcut, the ACL on the shared data folder, and the Add/Remove Programs entry.
- 4 Click **Open Start menu folder** to verify the shortcut landed in `C:\ProgramData\Microsoft\Windows\Start Menu\Programs\`. Windows Search sometimes takes a minute to pick up new entries — if the file is there but typing the name doesn't find it, give the indexer a moment and try again.

If the install fails, the elevated step shows a popup naming exactly which sub-step failed (copying the exe, setting the ACL, creating the shortcut, or writing the registry). Take a photo or note the message when reporting the issue.

Launching the app

After install, the easiest way:

- 1 Tap the **Windows key**.
- 2 Type **Bar**.
- 3 Press **Enter**.

The app comes up fullscreen. Press **F11** to toggle fullscreen, **Esc** to exit fullscreen, **Ctrl + Q** to quit.

Scanner tab — the main screen

This is where staff live all night. The cursor is parked in the input box; leave it there. When a CAC is swiped, the 18-character barcode types itself in and a verdict appears in under a second.

The three verdicts

Banner	Meaning	Counted?
 ALLOWED	Person is cleared. Banner shows which drink number this is.	Yes
 DENIED	Plain-English reason: limit reached, bar closed, banned, etc.	No
 INVALID SCAN	Scanner read garbage. Usually a bad swipe — try again.	No

Denied scans are **not** counted, so a person can't burn through their limit by trying again. Invalid scans aren't recorded at all.

What else is on the screen

- **Decoded box** — DoD ID, category, branch of the last person scanned, plus a running drink count.
- **Session line at the bottom** — current operating window (e.g. *“Open 17:00 → 02:00”*) so you can confirm the right rules are in effect at a glance.
- **Drinks served (bottom-left)** — running tally of every allowed scan in the current window. Denied and invalid scans don't count, so this matches what was actually served. Resets when the session rolls over or when an admin does a manual reset.
- **Clear button** — blanks the last decoded result. Handy between customers if you want a clean screen.

If the input box ever loses focus (someone clicked away), just click anywhere on the Scanner tab and it pops back to the input.

Hours tab — when the bar counts

Controls *when* drinks are counted. Two modes:

Mode	What it does
Operating hours	Set an open and close time. Counts reset automatically at next open.
Rolling window	Count drinks scanned in the last <i>N</i> hours (1 – 168). Slides continuously.

Switch with the radio button at the top. Fields for the other mode are hidden so you can't edit them by accident.

 **Tip:** If you leave Open and Close both at 00:00 in Operating-hours mode, the app treats the bar as open 24 hours.

Limits tab — drinks per person

One number: the maximum drinks any single person can be served in a session. Default is **3**.

Once a person hits the limit, every subsequent scan from them flashes red with *“You’ve had N drinks today (limit N)”* until:

- the session ends (Operating-hours mode), or
- the rolling window slides past their earlier drinks (Rolling mode), or
- you do a **manual reset** on the [Reset tab](#).

Roster tab — who’s eligible

Two side-by-side checklists. A scan is allowed only if **both** its category and branch are checked.

Column	Examples
Categories (PCC)	Active Duty, Reserve, Retiree, Dependent, Contractor
Branches	Army, Navy, Marines, Air Force, Space Force, Coast Guard

Each column has **All** and **None** buttons that flip every box at once — handy for “deny everything and tick on just the few I want.”

Banned tab — block specific people

Deny one specific DoD ID regardless of the roster.

1

Type their **10-digit EDIPI** in the EDIPI box.

2 Optionally type an **expiry date** as **YYYYMMDD** (e.g. **20261231** for “until 31 December 2026”). Leave blank for a permanent ban.

3 Click **Add**.

To lift a ban: click the entry in the list, hit **Remove selected**. Expired bans display **(EXPIRED)** in the list but stop denying scans automatically on their expiry date — no manual cleanup needed.

Reset tab — wipe today’s counts and change the password

For shift changes or a manual “start the night over.”

1 **Unlock the tab** with the admin password if it’s still locked (see [Unlocking settings](#)).

2 Click **Reset drinks for the day**.

3 Confirm in the popup. All drink counts are wiped immediately.

Every reset is recorded in the **Public reset log** below — that log is permanent and lists each reset with its date and time. The log can’t be edited or deleted. This is your accountability trail.

Changing the admin password

Below the reset button is a **Change admin password** box. While the tab is unlocked:

1 Type a new password in **New password**.

2 Re-type it in **Confirm**.

3 Click **Change password**.

Passwords must be at least 4 characters. The change takes effect immediately — anyone who already unlocked stays unlocked until the 5-minute timer expires, but the next unlock will require the new password. Each password change is recorded in the **Logs** tab as a generic “*admin password changed*” entry (the

password itself is never written to disk in clear text).

Logs tab — what happened and when

A read-only feed of every admin event:

- Unlocks and locks
- Settings changes (with before/after values)
- Bans added or removed
- Manual resets
- Backup exports

You can't edit or delete entries. Hit **Refresh** to reload after something just happened. This is the place to look when someone asks *“who changed the limit last Thursday?”*

Backup tab — export and import

The Backup tab does two things:

Action	Requires unlock?	Notes
Export full backup	No	Saves a <code>.zip</code> of every setting + log.
Import full backup	Yes (password)	Overwrites all settings and logs on this machine.

 **Import is destructive.** It **replaces** the current settings and logs with the backup. There's a confirmation dialog before anything is overwritten, but there's no undo afterward.

 **Heads-up:** the import also replaces the saved admin password with the one stored in the backup. If you import a backup made on another machine, the password on this PC becomes that machine's password (or `admin` if it never had one set).

Unlocking settings

For everyday scanning, the Scanner tab is always available. Anything that changes configuration sits behind a lock:

- Hours
- Limits
- Roster
- Banned
- Reset (drinks + change password)
- Backup → Import

Each locked tab shows a pink banner reading **LOCKED — enter the admin password to enable editing.**

How to unlock

- 1 Click **Unlock** on the banner.
- 2 A small popup appears. Type the **admin password** and press **Enter** (or click **Unlock**).
- 3 The banner turns green.
- 4 You have **5 minutes** to make changes before the app auto-locks.
- 5 Click **Lock** on the banner to lock immediately.

Every change you make while unlocked is recorded in the [Logs tab](#).

🔑 The default password is `admin`. Change it the first time you unlock — see [Changing the admin password](#). If you forget it, see [Recovering a lost password](#) below.

Recovering a lost password

The password hash lives in `settings.json` inside the shared data folder (see [Where the app stores its data](#)). With local admin rights on the PC you can edit it:

- 1 Close BarScanner.
- 2 Open `C:\ProgramData\CACBarScanner\settings.json` in Notepad (run Notepad **as administrator** if you can't save).
- 3 Delete the line that starts with `"admin_password_hash":` (or set the value to `""`).
- 4 Save and relaunch BarScanner — the default password (`admin`) is accepted again. Change it right away.

Keyboard shortcuts

Key	What it does
F11	Toggle fullscreen (kiosk mode)
Esc	Exit fullscreen
Ctrl + Q	Quit the app
Enter	Finish a scan manually (most USB scanners do this for you)

Where the app stores its data

Everything lives in `C:\ProgramData\CACBarScanner\` — Windows's standard machine-wide application-data folder. The folder is set up during install with read/write access for every user on the PC, which is what makes the configuration shared.

File	What's in it
<code>settings.json</code>	Hours, limits, roster, ban list, password hash.
<code>scans.jsonl</code>	Running drink counts (one record per scan).
<code>audit.jsonl</code>	Every admin action — unlocks, changes, resets, exports.
<code>resets.jsonl</code>	Every manual drink reset, with date and time.

You don't normally need to touch any of these — the app reads and writes them automatically. The **Backup** tab is the supported way to copy or move them.

Uninstalling

Two ways to start uninstall:

- **Settings** → **Apps** → **Installed apps** → find **CAC Bar Scanner** → click the ⋮ menu → **Uninstall**.
- Or in the **Start menu**, right-click **CAC Bar Scanner** → **Uninstall**.

Either way:

- 1 Windows runs the app one last time in uninstall mode.
- 2 A small dialog asks whether to also delete settings + logs.
 - **Leave unchecked** to keep the data (a future reinstall picks back up where you left off).
 - **Tick the box** for a complete wipe.
- 3 Click **Uninstall** in the dialog.
- 4 Approve the UAC prompt with **Yes**.

The Start menu entry, Add/Remove Programs listing, and `C:\Program Files\CAC Bar Scanner\` folder are all cleaned up. The folder finishes deleting itself on the next reboot — that's normal Windows behavior (the running uninstaller can't delete itself in real time).